

Synthetic Benchmarks

For those who plan to use their machines for high-end games or 3D modelling, 3DMark scores affect buying decisions. The Intel D975XBX and MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition were neck to neck in 3DMark 05, but the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition won by a hairsbreadth.

PCMark 2005 saw the Intel D975XBX beat the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition. These results suggest that the D975XBX is a very good board even for day-to-day applications. In SiSoft Sandra 2007 Engineer's edition, the CPU scores for 975X-based motherboards were nearly the same. The 975X board scores were more than triple what the nForce 4 SLI-based could manage. This is because of the power of Core 2 Duo CPUs and support for higher RAM frequencies. While memory bandwidth scores for nForce 4 SLI boards were similar, the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition scored considerably over the Intel D975XBX. Filesystem scores were almost identical across the board.

Real-World Benchmarks

Our video encoding test saw the Intel D975XBX beating everything, with a total time of just 70 seconds. The MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition came close, with 72 seconds. The P4N brothers took nearly 60 per cent more time to finish the same task.

Our Conclusion

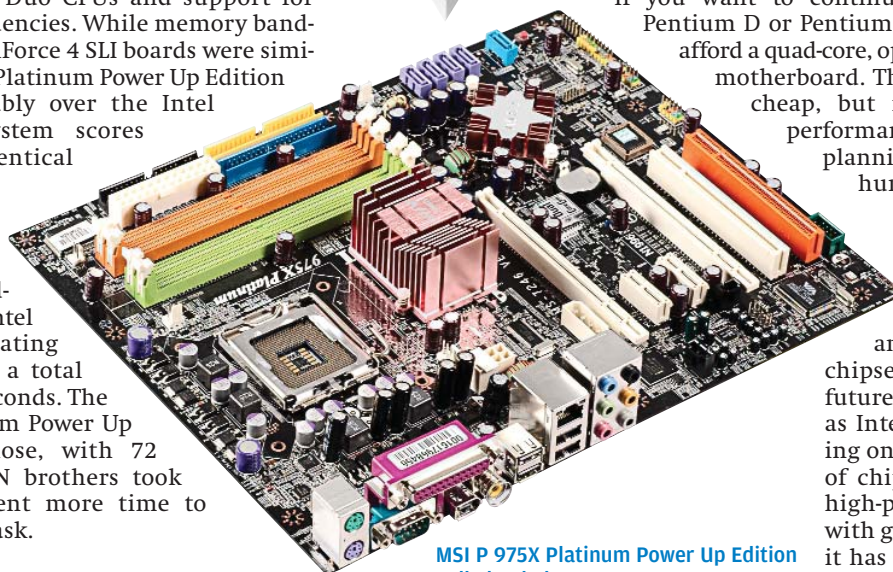
The Intel 975XBX was the top performer with the highest scores in most benchmarks, followed closely by the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition. These boards had a clear advantage thanks to the 975X chipset.

With its Creative SoundBlaster Live! 24-bit audio and Dual Gigabit LAN, the MSI P4N Diamond was clearly the most feature rich board in this category. It also had a good number of accessories bundled.

When it comes to price, the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition and MSI P4N Diamond cost the same. This was really surprising—the MSI P4N is an older board, and its performance is nowhere close to that of the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition!

Decision Maker

Segment	Usage Pattern	Solution
Home/office use	Surfing, word processing, presentations, and casual gaming	ASRock Conroe 945G-DVI, ECS 945G-M3, MSI K9NU Neo V
Professional use	3D designing, desktop publishing, audio/video editing, and occasional gaming	Gigabyte GA-965P-DS3, Gigabyte M59SLI-S5 F3, ASUS A8R MVP
Enthusiast	The latest games, overclocking, and upgradability	Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6, Intel D 975XBX, Biostar Tforce 590 SLI, ASUS Crosshair



MSI P 975X Platinum Power Up Edition Fully loaded

The *Digit Best Buy Gold* award goes to the Intel D975XBX, and Silver goes to the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition, due to its decent performance and value for money.

Our Conclusion

If you want to continue using your older Pentium D or Pentium 4 CPU until you can afford a quad-core, opt for a 945G/GZ-based motherboard. These boards are quite cheap, but not very strong on performance. If you are not planning to upgrade in a hurry, steer clear of 945G/GZ chipsets. The same goes for the nForce 4 SLI chipset.

For a performance freak, 975X chipsets are good. Their future is doubtful, however, as Intel seems to be focusing on the newer 965 series of chipsets. If you want a high-performance system with good upgrade options, it has to be a P965 chipset-based board. You get good performance, and the promise of quad-core support to boot!

Final Thoughts

For the duration of these extensive tests, we took the opportunity to spend some quality time with a few of these boards, and spent a number of late nights gaming away to glory. A motherboard seems an unlikely candidate to get up close to: after all, it's not a personal device like a cell phone or MP3 player. However, motherboards do have certain inherent characteristics that tend to become noticeable once you actually get into the finer nuances of tuning them and using them for extended periods.

Judging by the motherboards we received this time, manufacturers are attempting to make strong inroads into personalising motherboards: it's part of product strategy, we feel—trying to get us to view the impersonal motherboard as a lifestyle product.

What really matters is that manufacturers have also put thought into the pricing—expensive isn't necessarily stylish now. Even the top-end boards offer serious value for the features they bring, and there's never been a better time to buy a motherboard. ☐

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Contact Sheet Motherboards

Brand	Company	Phone	Web Site
Axper	Priya Limited	022-66663100	www.priyagroup.com
Asus	ASUSTeK Computer Inc.	022-40058888	http://in.asus.com
MSI	Micro Star International (MSI)	011-41758808 / 09	www.msi-india.com
Gigabyte	GIGABYTE Technology India Ltd	022-26526696 / 30616666	www.giga-byte.co.in
Biostar	Top Notch Infotronics (I) Pvt Ltd	044-26616202	www.zebronics.com
ECS	Mediatech India Distribution Pvt Ltd	022-26361111	www.mediatechindia.com
ASRock	Abacus Peripherals Pvt Ltd	022-66923941 / 44 / 45	www.abacusperipherals.com
Intel	Intel	080-25075000	www.intel.com/in
Sapphire	Aditya Infotech Ltd.	011-26223810 / 26223811	www.adityagroup.com